

BITS PILANI, DUBAI CAMPUS

Dubai International Academic City, U.A.E.

Semester II 2024-25

Quiz (CLOSED BOOK)

Course No: GS F211

Course Title: Modern Political Concepts

Date: March 7, 2025

Time: 90 mins

Maximum Marks: 20

Weightage: 20

Part I

Name.....

ID.....

*Please circle the most appropriate option (**Only one**)*

Q1) Those who are not interested in politics are not interested in their future. This is the essence of one of the philosophers who is quoted in this course module. Identify the philosopher from the option below.

- a) Karl Marx b) Bertolt Brecht c) **Martha Gellhorn** d) Otto Von Bismarck

Q 2) The End Goal of Revolutionary Socialism is

- a) Change government through a revolution.
b) Establish dictatorship of proletariat
c) Oust Bourgeoisie from power.
d) **Establish a classless society.**

Q3) There is a growing demand for a Universal Basic Income (UBI). Amid these demands, referendum was conducted in one of the countries to assess public opinion over UBI. Identify the country.....

- a) Switzerland b) **Sweden** c) Slovakia d) Slovenia

Q4) One of the philosophers wrote that we are owner of the land, and the income of the land should be shared equally among the people. It is matter of justice not charity. From this argument emanated the idea of what we know Unconditional/Universal Basic Income now. Identify the philosopher

- a) Thomas More b) **Thomas Paine** c) Luis Vive d) Karl Marx

Q5) All the wealth in this world has been generated through labour. Who among the following philosophers said so.

- a) Karl Marx b) F. A. Hayek c) Adam Smith d) John M. Keynes

Q6) Capitalism is endlessly adaptable. The capitalists come up with brilliant solutions. In the three documentaries that you have watched the presenter attribute these statements to one of the three authors. Identify the author?

- a) John M. Keynes b) F. A. Hayek c) Karl Marx.

Q7) Just in Time is the concept associated to one of the forms of Capitalism that you have studied during this course. Identify which form of Capitalism espouses this concept?

- a) Crony Capitalism b) Entrepreneurial capitalism c) Oligarchic capitalism d) Big-firm capitalism

Q8) Correctly match the idea and author/Philosopher

(Draw a line and take the line to 1. 2. 3. Whichever is appropriate. Do an exercise on a rough sheet before making a final attempt)

Philosopher/author	Idea
A. Man is a Solitary and social Being	1. Karl Marx
B. Invisible hand	2. Einstein
C. Economic growth through Stimulus	3. Adam Smith
D. Boom and Bust	4. Keynes
E. Classless Society	5. Hayek
	6. Thomas Paine
	7. Aristotal

Q9) Correctly match the book and author/Philosopher

(Draw a line and take the line to 1. 2. 3. Whichever is appropriate. Do an exercise on a rough sheet before making a final attempt) (2 marks)

Philosopher/author	Book
A. Das Capital	1. Marx and Engels
B. Theory of Moral Sentiment	2. Einstein
C. Why Socialism ?	3. Adam Smith
D. Communist Manifesto	4. Keynes
E. Road to Serfdom	5. Hayek
	6. Thomas Paine
	7. Aristotal

Please detach the MCQ Part I before attempting the next section and hand it over to the Invigilator

Part II

Attempt your answer in the essay format. PPT format answer will NOT be marked. Answer your question in at least 500 words. (

Q1) a) What are the core arguments of Keynes and Hayek when it comes to economy/market. How they differ with each others. (2.5 marks)

b) Why do the present governments/ruling parties prefer Keynes over Hayek? Debate (2.5 marks)

Part III

This part is based on recommended reading shared with you on Crony capitalism. Do not deviate from the recommended reading while answering the questions of this part.

Q2) Read the below statement/remarks care fully

“....those who exercise political power should have no economic motives and those who are engaged in economic activities should have no share in politics.”

- a) The above statement is attributed to a philosopher/author? Name the author **(0.5 marks)**
- b) What the author is trying to convey? Should the businessmen/corporate be barred from contesting election? Debate **(2 marks)**

Q3) Read the below statement/remarks carefully

“..the crooked politician needs the businessman to provide the funds that allow him to supply patronage to the poor and fight elections. The corrupt businessman needs crooked politicians to get public resources and contracts cheaply. and the politician needs the votes of the poor and underprivileged. Every constituency is tied to another in a cycle of dependence which ensures that status quo prevails.”

- a) The above statement is attributed to a philosopher/author? Name the author **(0.5 marks)**
- b) What the author is trying to convey? How can this statement be related to present day scenario.? Explain **(2 marks)**

BITS PILANI, DUBAI CAMPUS

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Semester II 2024-25

Compre Essay (CLOSED BOOK)

Course No: GS F211

Course Title: Modern Political Concepts

Date: May 30, 2025

Time: 03 hrs mins Maximum Marks: 40

Weightage: 40

Part II (20 marks)

Please answer each questions in this section in at least 500 words each.

Q1) Equality is a common theme in most of the ideologies/political concepts that you have studied in this course. However, its interpretations and ways to achieve it differs. Please explain how following ideologies views equality and how it wants to achieve it.

- a) Feminism b) Gandhism c) Anarchism d) Communism/Marxism

Q2) Consider following arguments.

Argument I (Social Contract Theory)– Man lived in state of nature before the emergence of the State. State of nature was “the war of all against all,” with life becoming anarchic, barbarous, and chaotic. In Hobbes theory of the Social Contract everyone abandoned their natural right, conveying it instead to some institution. This institution is the state. The purpose of the state was to avoid state of nature and create a state to safeguard individuals.

Argument II- (Mutual aid Theory)

Society has evolved through evolution of voluntary cooperation from the primitive tribe, peasant village, and medieval commune to a variety of modern associations—trade unions, learned societies, the Red Cross—that have continued to practice mutual support despite the rise of the coercive bureaucratic state. The trend of modern history was pointing back toward decentralized, nonpolitical, cooperative societies in which people could develop their creative faculties without interference from rulers, clerics, or soldiers.

What these two arguments aim to convey? Which of the above arguments seems more reasonable and scientific to you and why?

Q3) What is Feminism? What does it want to achieve? What does the Documentary- Feminism Inshall conveys about the Arab Feminism.? Explain.

Q4) What are the key features of Anarchism? Discuss.

Part III (10 marks)

Q5) You have learnt to summarise the key concepts as part of Project Based Learning assignments in this course. This question is aimed at assessing the Learning Outcome of the entire exercise.

Applying the processes learnt during the exercise please sum up the text in 400 words conveying the essence of the text. (7 marks)

Eight Marxist Claims That May Surprise You

By

Mitchell Aboulafia

Critics of Marx often get the great socialist thinker wrong. We are here to set the record straight.

There are many ways to interpret Marx. Many of them legitimate. But many others seek to dismiss Marx by invoking anticommunist echo chamber rhetoric. They deride him as a sterile economic determinist or lambast his analysis and predictions as horribly wrongheaded.

Marx was not always correct (who is?). But he was either correct or made defensible claims more often than many people realize. And he remains worth heeding.

So with an eye toward rebutting some of the more wild-eyed portrayals of the great socialist thinker, here are eight claims that any credible interpretation of Marx or Marxism should include.

1

Marx did not simply dismiss capitalism. He was impressed by it. He argued that it has been the most productive system that the world has seen.

The bourgeoisie, during its rule of scarce one hundred years, has created more massive and more colossal productive forces than have all preceding generations together. Subjection of Nature's forces to man, machinery, application of chemistry to industry and agriculture, steam-navigation, railways, electric telegraphs, clearing of whole continents for cultivation, canalisation of rivers, whole populations conjured out of the ground — what earlier century had even a presentiment that such productive forces slumbered in the lap of social labour?

2

Marx accurately predicted that capitalism would foster what is today referred to as globalization. He saw capitalism creating a world market in which countries would become increasingly interdependent.

The bourgeoisie has through its exploitation of the world market given a cosmopolitan character to production and consumption in every country. To the great chagrin of Reactionists, it has drawn from under the feet of industry the national ground on which it stood. All old-established national industries have been destroyed or are daily being destroyed. . . . In place of the old local and national seclusion and self-sufficiency, we have intercourse in every direction, universal inter-dependence of nations.

3

Unlike earlier societies, which tended to conserve traditions and ways of life, capitalism thrives on inventing new and alternative ways of producing that affect how we live. Technologies change our lives at an ever more rapid pace. Old products must make way for new ones (and those who make them).

Although capitalists typically portray this as an unalloyed good, it can be deeply unsettling, even if particular changes are positive. It can lead people to feel that their values and ways of life no longer have a place in the world — that they are living deadwood. Also, employing new technologies and methods of production in the pursuit of profit for the few can lead to unanticipated consequences. (In

our own times, no doubt Marx would point to climate change as a consequence of unregulated capitalism.)

The bourgeoisie cannot exist without constantly revolutionising the instruments of production, and thereby the relations of production, and with them the whole relations of society. . . . Constant revolutionising of production, uninterrupted disturbance of all social conditions, everlasting uncertainty and agitation distinguish the bourgeois epoch from all earlier ones. All fixed, fast-frozen relations, with their train of ancient and venerable prejudices and opinions, are swept away, all new-formed ones become antiquated before they can ossify. All that is solid melts into air, all that is holy is profaned, and man is at last compelled to face with sober senses his real conditions of life, and his relations with his kind.

4

Powerful companies, concentrations of wealth, and new methods of production make it increasingly difficult for independent professionals and middle-class merchants to maintain their status. They end up with the wrong skill set or working for companies that have put their kind out of business. In other words, Marx anticipated the Walmartification of capitalist societies.

The lower strata of the middle class — the small tradespeople, shopkeepers, and retired tradesmen generally, the handicraftsmen and peasants — all these sink gradually into the proletariat, partly because their diminutive capital does not suffice for the scale on which Modern Industry is carried on, and is swamped in the competition with the large capitalists, partly because their specialised skill is rendered worthless by new methods of production.

5

Marx did not seek the abolition of all property. He did not want the vast majority of people to have fewer material goods. He was not an anti-materialist utopian. What he opposed was private property — the vast amounts of property and concentrated wealth owned by capitalists, the bourgeoisie. As a matter of fact, at the end of the passage below, he and Engels derisively accuse capitalism of depriving people of their “self-earned property.”

The distinguishing feature of Communism is not the abolition of property generally, but the abolition of bourgeois property. But modern bourgeois private property is the final and most complete expression of the system of producing and appropriating products, that is based on class antagonisms, on the exploitation of the many by the few.

In this sense, the theory of the Communists may be summed up in the single sentence: Abolition of private property.

We Communists have been reproached with the desire of abolishing the right of personally acquiring property as the fruit of a man’s own labour, which property is alleged to be the groundwork of all personal freedom, activity and independence.

Hard-won, self-acquired, self-earned property! Do you mean the property of petty artisan and of the small peasant, a form of property that preceded the bourgeois form? There is no need to abolish that; the development of industry has to a great extent already destroyed it, and is still destroying it daily.

6

Marx thought that human beings have a natural inclination to feel connected to the objects that they have made or created. He called this the “objectification” of labor, by which he meant that we put something of ourselves into our work. When one cannot connect with one’s own creation, when one feels “external” to it, alienation results. It’s as if you were to sculpt a statue, then someone took it from you, and you were never allowed to see or touch it again. Marx argued that workers were in a comparable position in nineteenth-century capitalist factories.

What, then, constitutes the alienation of labor?

First, the fact that labor is external to the worker, i.e., it does not belong to his intrinsic nature; that in his work, therefore, he does not affirm himself but denies himself, does not feel content but unhappy, does not develop freely his physical and mental energy but mortifies his body and ruins his mind. The worker therefore only feels himself outside his work, and in his work feels outside himself. He feels at home when he is not working, and when he is working he does not feel at home. His labor is therefore not voluntary, but coerced; it is forced labor.

7

Marx wanted us to be able to break free from the tyranny of the division of labor and long working days, which prevent individuals from developing different kinds of capacities and talents. We become servants to one kind of activity and other dimensions of our personalities are left undeveloped. In an aspirational passage, which he wrote as a young man, he framed his vision this way:

For as soon as the distribution of labour comes into being, each man has a particular, exclusive sphere of activity, which is forced upon him and from which he cannot escape. He is a hunter, a fisherman, a herdsman, or a critical critic, and must remain so if he does not want to lose his means of livelihood; while in communist society, where nobody has one exclusive sphere of activity but each can become accomplished in any branch he wishes, society regulates the general production and thus makes it possible for me to do one thing today and another tomorrow, to hunt in the morning, fish in the afternoon, rear cattle in the evening, criticise after dinner, just as I have a mind, without ever becoming hunter, fisherman, herdsman or critic.

8

Marx was not a crude economic determinist. How people think and act matters. In a letter Engels wrote after Marx’s death, he emphasized the importance of economics, but he also tried to make it clear that Marx and he were misinterpreted, and it was partially their own fault (notice the pointed dig at Marxists at the end of the passage).

Marx and I are ourselves partly to blame for the fact that the younger people sometimes lay more stress on the economic side than is due to it. We had to emphasise the main principle vis-à-vis our adversaries, who denied it, and we had not always the time, the place or the opportunity to give their due to the other elements involved in the interaction. But when it came to presenting a section of history, that is, to making a practical application, it was a different matter and there no error was permissible. Unfortunately, however, it happens only too often that people think they have fully understood a new theory and can apply it without more ado from the moment they have assimilated its main principles, and even those not always correctly. And I cannot exempt many of the more recent “Marxists” from this reproach, for the most amazing rubbish has been produced in this quarter, too. .

. .

Q6) a) Please identify the ideology/political leaning of the author of below piece. Write only one word (1 mark)

b) What Should be the definition of the platform worker. (2 marks)

Let no worker be treated like a 'replaceable component'

Vox Populi, Vox Dei is a daily column that runs on Page 1 of The Asahi Shimbun.

From the autumn of 1972, freelance journalist Satoshi Kamata worked undercover for six months as a seasonal laborer at a Toyota Motor Corp. plant to write a report.

The factory's conveyor belt system started operating at 6 a.m. and parts came down the assembly line every 80 seconds—too fast for Kamata to keep up with, no matter how frantically he wielded his hammer.

Kamata recorded the brutal working conditions in “Jidosha Zetsubo Kojo” (literally, “auto plant of despair”), a tour de force with powerful language and vivid descriptions that still grab the reader more than half a century after its publication.

For example, there is a scene where an exhausted Kamata returns from work to his shared dorm room and mulls over what it means to be a worker: “A worker is not even a machine ... He is just a component that's cheaper than a machine and easily replaceable.”

How about present-day workers?

As a matter of fact, the criteria by which a person is legally recognized as a worker has remained unchanged since 1985.

When I heard that the labor ministry established a panel of experts this month to review the criteria, I was surprised to realize that the matter had not even been addressed at all for 40 years.

The review has to do with so-called “platform workers”—defined as those who earn a living by performing work through online platforms.

Under the current criteria, an individual will be recognized as a worker only if they are under the direct supervision of their employer.

But it is unclear whether this applies to platform workers, such as Uber Eats and Amazon delivery personnel, who are “formally” self-employed but also use platform apps to follow AI-generated or algorithm-generated instructions regarding their delivery routes.

What matters in this era of diverse working styles is that every worker be allowed to speak out and receive protection when necessary.

If not, workers of the digital era will become “replaceable components” in the “plants of despair.”

—The Asahi Shimbun, May 20